From *Life of Galileo by* Bertolt Brecht, 1939.

No matter how famous or well reputed a person is, when she is hired as an official in a government agency, we are aware of the gap between her personal interests and the public interest. Public choice theory encourages us to engage in ‘politics without romance’. We will not build the republic by finding benevolent people. What we need are the frameworks where various kinds of self-interest are in conflict in the public arena, through well-specified rules of the game. The objective of reform is not to hire saints, but to achieve a state which yields good outcomes when each actor is self-interested.

Public choice theory has an important implication about how we think about institutions. There was a time when we would try to hire a competent and benevolent person to head an institution, and then leave all the decisions to her. Public choice theory has helped us see that we should stop searching for heroes and that we should not concentrate power in any one person. The capability of an institution lies not in personnel choices but in the arrangement of information, incentives and power. A sound institution is characterized by checks and balances, that create forces of accountability, that push the leadership of an organization to serve the people of India and not pursue their own self-interest.

The authors of the Constitution of India thought that the Speaker of the Lok Sabha was a gentleman, who would always be ethical and fair when determining what a money bill is. For a contrast, the authors of the United States Constitution, envisioned a president like Donald Trump. They wrote a document which is not a statement of hope about what a good president can do. Rather, it is a document that is focused on limiting the damage that a bad president can do.